

# Chapter 19

## The Verdict

The next morning...

Elara stood in front of the mirror, quietly getting ready.

The night at Roman's apartment kept replaying in her mind.

The rain.

The news.

Roman's calm voice.

*Take a rest, Elara. I'm here.*

She looked down at her phone.

There were several messages from Eva and Daniel.

She hadn't replied to any of them.

Today...

she needed to see Ethan.

Not because she wanted an explanation.

Because she wanted to look at him herself.

And finally understand how someone she had trusted for so long could have lied to her.

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The courthouse was surrounded by reporters.

Police vehicles stood near the entrance.

Cameras flashed whenever someone walked through the gates.

Elara stepped out of the car.

Roman was beside her.

He didn't ask why she had wanted to come.

He simply walked with her.

Inside...

the hearing was already underway.

Ethan's father sat with his lawyers.

For the first time...

he didn't look like the powerful man everyone had known.

There were no cameras under his control.

No people waiting for his instructions.

No influence left to hide behind.

The evidence against him had changed everything.

His interference in the old investigation had come to light.

The misuse of his position was being investigated.

Several assets connected to the alleged wrongdoing were also being examined for possible confiscation.

And his political career...

was effectively over.

Elara watched quietly.

Then the doors opened.

Ethan was brought through with officers.

His eyes moved across the hallway.

Then stopped on her.

He froze.

For a moment...

neither of them moved.

Elara slowly stepped forward.

Roman remained a few steps behind her.

Ethan looked exhausted.

"Elara..."

She stopped.

"You lied to me."

His eyes lowered.

"I know."

"For three years."

"I didn't know how to..."

"Don't."

Her voice was quiet.

But firm.

"I don't want another excuse."

Ethan looked at her.

"I was trying to protect..."

"Protect me?"

A bitter laugh escaped her.

"You made me hate someone who didn't deserve it."

Ethan had no answer.

Elara's eyes filled with tears.

"I trusted you."

"I know."

"No."

She shook her head.

"You don't."

Her voice trembled.

"You were the first person I trusted after everything happened."

Ethan looked away.

"And you used that."

A long silence followed.

Then Elara took a slow breath.

"I don't know what happens to you now."

She looked at him one last time.

"But whatever happens..."

"I'm not carrying your lie anymore."

Ethan looked at her.

"Elara..."

She turned away.

This time...

she didn't stop.

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Outside the courthouse...

the reporters were still waiting.

Questions came from every direction.

Roman gently guided Elara away from the crowd.

She remained silent until they reached the car.

Before getting inside...

she stopped.

"I thought seeing him would make me hate him."

Roman looked at her.

"And?"

Elara stared at the courthouse behind them.

"I don't know what I feel anymore."

Roman remained quiet for a moment.

Then said,

"Then don't decide today."

She looked at him.

"You always say things like that."

A faint smile appeared on his face.

"Maybe because you always try to solve everything in one day."

Despite everything...

a tiny smile appeared on Elara's face.

It disappeared almost immediately.

But Roman noticed it.

They got into the car.

As the courthouse disappeared behind them...

Elara looked out of the window.

For three years...

she had believed she knew the truth.

Now she understood something much more frightening.

The truth wasn't a single story.

It was a collection of pieces.

And she had only found the first few.

Roman looked at her quietly.

He knew there were still things she didn't know.

Things about that night.

Things about Noah.

Things about the people who had changed the story.

But for now...

he said nothing.

The car continued through Frankfurt.

And somewhere ahead...

the next piece of the truth was already waiting.

Elara sat quietly at the dining table.

Her coffee had gone cold.

She hadn't touched it.

Eva sat across from her.

Daniel stood near the television.

Her parents were there too.

No one seemed to know what to say.

Then the news presenter appeared on the screen.

"Good morning."

"Here is the latest update in the Ashford investigation."

Everyone became quiet.

Elara slowly lifted her eyes toward the television.

The headline appeared.

## **COURT DELIVERS DECISION IN ASHFORD CASE**

The reporter continued.

"The court has found Ethan Ashford responsible for multiple criminal acts connected to several deaths, the destruction and manipulation of evidence, and the obstruction of an earlier investigation."

Elara's fingers tightened around the edge of the table.

The screen changed.

A photograph of Ethan appeared.

Then his father's.

Daniel lowered the volume slightly.

The reporter continued.

"The court considered the circumstances of the deaths separately. Under German criminal law, negligent killing is treated differently from intentional killing. Section 222 of the German Criminal Code provides for imprisonment of up to five years or a fine for negligent homicide, while intentional killing under Section 212 carries a minimum sentence of five years."

Eva looked at Elara.

Elara didn't move.

The reporter continued.

"In this case, the court found the evidence against Ethan sufficient to establish responsibility for multiple offences."

A new headline appeared.

## **ETHAN ASHFORD SENTENCED TO A LENGTHY PRISON TERM**

The exact sentence appeared beneath it.

**Ethan Ashford: 15 years imprisonment.**

Elara's breath caught.

Daniel stared at the screen.

"Fifteen years..."

The reporter continued.

"The court also ordered the withdrawal of Ethan Ashford's driving privileges. Under German law, a court can revoke a person's driving licence when the offence shows that the person is unfit to drive, including in certain alcohol-related driving cases."

Elara looked down.

For a moment...

she felt nothing.

No anger.

No satisfaction.

Just emptiness.

Then the reporter moved to Ethan's father.

"The court has also ruled against Ethan Ashford's father following evidence of interference with the investigation and abuse of his influence."

His photograph appeared again.

"The court has ordered the confiscation of property and assets connected to the criminal conduct where legally justified."

Daniel quietly whispered,

"So it's all gone."

Her father shook his head.

"Not necessarily everything."

"Only what the court determines is connected to the offences can be confiscated."

The reporter continued.

"Because of the conviction and the resulting sentence, additional legal consequences may also affect his eligibility to hold public office. Under Section 45 of the German Criminal Code, a person convicted of a serious offence and sentenced to at least one year of imprisonment can lose the ability to hold public office and certain electoral rights for five years."

The room became completely silent.

The man who had once been powerful...

was no longer standing above the law.

His political career was finished.

His influence was gone.

And the reputation he had protected for years...

had collapsed in a single week.

Eva looked at Elara.

"Are you okay?"

Elara didn't answer.

The television showed another headline.

## **ROMAN ASHFORD CLEARED IN THREE-YEAR-OLD CASE**

Her eyes filled with tears.

For three years...

she had believed the opposite.

Three years of anger.

Three years of confusion.

Three years of blaming someone who had never deserved it.

She closed her eyes.

A quiet tear rolled down her cheek.

Daniel lowered his gaze.

"Elara..."

She shook her head.

"I'm okay."

But her voice didn't sound convincing.

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Later that afternoon...

Elara sat alone in her room.

The television was off.

Her phone lay beside her.

Roman's contact was open on the screen.

She stared at his name.

Then locked the phone.

She remembered his apartment.

The towel.

The water.

His quiet voice.

*Take a rest, Elara.*

*I'm here.*

She closed her eyes.

For the first time...  
she wasn't afraid of Roman.  
She was afraid of how much she wanted to believe him.  
A knock came at the door.  
Her mother entered.  
"Elara?"  
She looked up.  
"Yes?"  
"Your father wants to know if you're coming downstairs."  
"I'll come later."  
Her mother nodded.  
Before leaving, she looked at her daughter.  
"Are you sure you're okay?"  
Elara gave a small smile.  
"I think I'm just tired."  
Her mother left.  
Elara looked toward the window.  
The city was slowly returning to normal.  
But her life wasn't.  
Not anymore.

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## **Across the City**

Roman stood near the window of his apartment.  
His investigator had just left.  
The case was finally moving through the proper legal process.  
The evidence was secured.  
The recordings had been handed over.  
The truth was no longer something he had to prove alone.  
But Roman wasn't thinking about Ethan.  
He was thinking about Elara.  
His phone was in his hand.  
He opened her contact.  
Typed something.

Deleted it.  
Typed again.  
Then stopped.  
He put the phone down.  
Some things couldn't be said through a screen.

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That evening...  
Elara's phone vibrated.  
She looked down.  
A message from Roman.

**Can we talk?**

She stared at it.  
Her fingers moved slowly.

**About what?**

The reply came after a few seconds.

**About everything you still don't know.**

Elara looked at the screen.  
Her heart beat faster.

She typed:

**I'm listening.**

Roman's reply appeared.

**Then let me tell you the truth.**

Elara stared at those words.

For a long moment...

she didn't move.

Then she smiled faintly.

Not because everything was okay.

It wasn't.

But for the first time...

she was ready to hear the truth without letting someone else decide what she should believe.

She placed the phone beside her.

Outside...

Frankfurt was glowing beneath the evening lights.

And somewhere across the city...

Roman was preparing to tell her everything.

But there was still one thing he hadn't told her.

The thing that had been waiting inside that abandoned library...

since the night everything changed.

And perhaps...

that was the truth Elara had been searching for all along.